ORANGE ENGLISH

FREE IELTS SPEAKING GAME · GROUPS OF THREE OR A STUDY BUDDY · 20–25 MINUTES

Don't Say "Umm"

A fluency game for IELTS Speaking. One person asks, one answers, and one listens and keeps score. The lowest score wins.

12 Part 1 questions | 2 Part 2 long turns | 6 Part 3 questions | 5 listener cards | Score sheet

START HERE · 2 MINUTES

What's your "umm"?

Ask: "What do people say in your language when they're thinking? Can we hear it?" Everyone says theirs. Then agree which sounds to listen for in English.

HOW TO PLAY

1. Get into groups of three: an **interviewer**, a **speaker** and a **listener**.
2. Choose one listener card for the round.
3. The interviewer asks a question. The speaker answers for about 30 seconds, then the follow-up if there's time.
4. The listener counts the habit on the score sheet.
5. Swap roles until everyone has spoken. Lowest score wins.

SCORING

1	each time the listener hears the habit
½	if the speaker corrects it straight away: "Yesterday I go… went shopping."
1	if the speaker starts the whole sentence again
0	for a silent thinking pause

HANDS UP OR NOT?

Optional. The listener can raise a hand each time, but counting quietly is usually better: interrupting breaks the speaker's flow.

LAST ROUND · NO SCORE

Ask one more question and don't keep score. The listener tells the speaker one thing they did well.

Study buddy? In pairs, your partner asks and keeps score. On your own, record your answer, count as you play it back, then try again and beat your score.

Print pages 2–6 single-sided for each group and cut along the dotted lines. Written by Lindsey, former IELTS examiner · Orange English · orangeenglish.nl

Listener cards CHOOSE ONE PER ROUND

Read the card aloud so everyone agrees what counts.

FLUENCY

Your "umm"

Count the hesitation sound your group agreed on. A silent pause to think is free.

1 point each time · ½ if corrected straight away

FLUENCY

Which "like"?

Count "like" when it's a filler: *"It's, like, really quiet."* Don't count "I like" or "looks like".

1 point each time

GRAMMAR

Listen for the past

Count a present verb for a finished event: *"Yesterday I go shopping."* A present fact is fine: *"She lives nearby."*

1 point each time · ½ if corrected straight away

REFERENCE

He or she?

Count he and she switching by accident while the speaker describes one person. Accept the pronouns the person uses.

1 point each time · ½ if corrected straight away

VOCABULARY

Spot a repeated word

The speaker chooses a word they overuse, such as "nice", "good" or "very". Count it from the second time they say it.

1 point each time

Score sheet

Speaker	Round 1	Round 2	Round 3	Round 4	Total
Habit this round →					

Everyday life PART 1

Ask the question in bold. Use the follow-up to keep talking.

ROUTINES

How often do you cook at home?

Follow-up: What do you usually make when you're in a hurry?

PLACES

Where do you go when you want some quiet?

Follow-up: What do you like about that place?

FREE TIME

What do you enjoy doing on a free afternoon?

Follow-up: Do you usually do that alone or with someone else?

HOME

Which room do you spend the most time in?

Follow-up: What do you tend to do there?

TRAVEL

How do you usually get around your town?

Follow-up: Would you like to change anything about that journey?

MUSIC

When do you usually listen to music?

Follow-up: Does the type of music you choose depend on what you're doing?

Memories & people PART 1

"Looking back" cards suit the past tense round. "People" cards suit the he or she round.

LOOKING BACK

What did you do last weekend?

Follow-up: Was that a typical weekend for you?

LOOKING BACK

What games did you enjoy as a child?

Follow-up: Where did you usually play them?

LOOKING BACK

When did you last try a new food?

Follow-up: What did you think of it?

PEOPLE

Who taught you a skill you still use?

Follow-up: How did that person help you learn?

PEOPLE

Who in your family do you enjoy talking to?

Follow-up: What did that person tell you the last time you spoke?

PEOPLE

Which teacher do you remember best from school?

Follow-up: What did that teacher do that made lessons memorable?

The long turn PART 2

Take one minute to prepare, then speak for one to two minutes. The listener keeps score for the whole talk.

PEOPLE

Describe someone who helped you learn something difficult.

You should say:

- who this person was
- what you were trying to learn
- how this person helped you

and explain how you felt when you made progress.

1 minute to prepare · 1–2 minutes to speak

Interviewer, after the talk: Have you helped anyone learn the same thing?

PLACES

Describe a public place you enjoyed visiting for the first time.

You should say:

- where the place was
- when you first went there
- what you did during your visit

and explain what made you want to spend time there.

1 minute to prepare · 1–2 minutes to speak

Interviewer, after the talk: Would you go back to that place?

Wider discussion PART 3

Use after the matching long turn, or draw a fresh card for the last round with no score.

AFTER "PEOPLE"

Why do some people prefer learning from a friend?

Follow-up: When might a professional teacher be a better choice?

AFTER "PEOPLE"

How has technology changed the way people learn practical skills?

Follow-up: Which skills are still difficult to learn online?

AFTER "PEOPLE"

Should schools give pupils more chances to teach each other?

Follow-up: What problems might a teacher need to manage?

AFTER "PLACES"

What makes a public space welcoming to different age groups?

Follow-up: Can the same space meet all their needs?

AFTER "PLACES"

How have the places where people meet changed over time?

Follow-up: What do you think has caused those changes?

AFTER "PLACES"

How should towns decide which public spaces to improve first?

Follow-up: Whose views should they take into account?